

The Noble Dhāraṇī Known as the Ocean of Dharma

Ārya-dharmasāgara-nāma-dhāraṇī · Toh 654 · Derge Kangyur

འཕགས་པ་ཆས་ཀྱི་རྒྱུ་ཆོ་

Toh 654 in the Kangyur is a dhāraṇī text known in Sanskrit as the Ārya-dharmasāgara-nāma-dhāraṇī and in Tibetan as Phags pa chos kyi rgya mtsho, meaning "The Noble Ocean of Dharma." As a dhāraṇī sūtra, it belongs to the class of canonical texts that present sacred incantations within a narrative scriptural frame, here set at the Deer Park of Ṛṣipatana near Vārāṇasī, where the Buddha addresses an assembly of five hundred monks on the profound and subtle nature of the Dharma he has realized. The text was translated from Sanskrit into Tibetan by the Indian master Prajñāvarman together with the great editor-translator Ye shes sde and their colleagues, whose collaboration on canonical translation was especially influential during the early period of Buddhist transmission in Tibet. Sitting among the dhāraṇī texts of the Kangyur, it reflects the tradition of presenting meditative and protective incantations within the authoritative setting of a buddha's direct discourse.

Translated by the Indian master Prajñāvarman and the great editor-translator, the venerable Ye shes sde, and others, who rendered, revised, and established it.

In the language of India: Ārya-dharmasāgara-nāma-dhāraṇī. In the Tibetan language: the dhāraṇī known as "The Noble Ocean of Dharma."

Homage to all buddhas and bodhisattvas.

Thus did I hear. At one time the Blessed One was dwelling together with a great Saṅgha of monks — a full five hundred monks — in the Deer Park called Ṛṣipatana at Vārāṇasī. Then the Blessed One addressed the monks, and those monks listened to the Blessed One, and the Blessed One spoke these words:

"O monks, I have realized a Dharma that is profound and difficult to see, difficult to realize, subtle, investigated, to be understood by the learned and the wise. I have turned the wheel of Dharma for the benefit of the many, for the happiness of the many, out of compassion for the world, for the welfare of the multitude, for the benefit and happiness of gods and human beings. In order to turn the unobstructed wheel of Dharma, one must accomplish certainty alone.

O monks, there is this category of Dharma known as 'The Ocean of Dharma' dhāraṇī, which has been set forth and explained by Tathāgatas, arhats, perfectly and fully awakened buddhas — those endowed with the intelligence of mindfulness, endowed with the intelligence of understanding, endowed with the intelligence of realization, endowed with the intelligence of stability, endowed with the intelligence of wisdom, endowed with the most excellent speech, endowed with the most excellent eloquence, possessed of knowledge and vision. Those who know it and those who hold it will swiftly attain five qualities. What are the five? They are as follows: they will come to be endowed with the mindfulness that retains what has been heard; they will come to be endowed with the intelligence of non-forgetfulness, along with understanding such that the Dharma teachings they have grasped do not become lost; they will come to be endowed with sharp and keenly penetrating realization; they will come to be endowed with unobstructed eloquence in engaging with letters, meanings, and words; and they will come to be skilled in recollecting former states of existence, having directly known the causal path of sentient beings. These five qualities were established by the Tathāgatas, arhats, perfectly and fully awakened buddhas of the past. I too now establish them."

Then the Blessed One addressed the venerable Ānanda: "Ānanda, I shall teach you the comprehensive basis — the summation of all Dharmas — and thereby you will come to hear Dharmas you have not heard. Dharmas you have heard, you will come to retain. Dharmas you have retained, you will come to practice. Dharmas you have practiced, you will cause others to understand.

The five divisions of terminology are as follows: the division of the terminology of formations; likewise, the division of the terminology of Dharmas not yet heard; the division of the terminology of the unsurpassed; the division of the terminology of syllables investigated stage by stage; and the division of the terminology of definitive words and words of various expressions.

Among these, the following are mantra-words endowed with the power to invoke splendor and majesty: all yakṣas, rākṣasas, spirits, hungry ghosts, and flesh-eating beings of the world-realm of the four continents who have entered Jambudvīpa shall offer that person a variety of foods and medicines. The other mantra-words arising from Dharma do no harm to others. They were spoken by the Tathāgata, approved of by gods, nāgas, yakṣas, and gandharvas (scent-eaters). The guardians of the teaching are these."

"Ānanda, listen to these words of secret mantra. You may feel regret later. Syād yatheda nam, karma keta manuṣche, rate ruta grandra ma, thumana, nailata, asaṃkula sthā, bumi anusmari, iśaṃ gama iśa sthā, klena anugate, yāmula gumbhe, pabhe magur vayava, asya vākya sya vilamga, belama tha, śrī va varī pañcaka, prasate, ava bela, agra bela, niśikhu ucejume, ucejume. Ānanda, these are the yakṣa-invocation accomplishments, and they bind those yakṣas who render homage and make offerings to the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly and fully awakened Kāśyapa, and who perform rites of propitiation for him. Ānanda, hold fast to those spoken by the Tathāgata regarding the accomplishment of yakṣa invocation.

Ānanda, whoever holds, retains, and completely fulfills these words of secret mantra that are free of fault — the four great kings abide in their minds in attendance upon that person. Ānanda, through holding these words of secret mantra, one will come to possess mindfulness. One will never be separated from the buddhas.

Ānanda, in the eastern continent of Pūrvavideha there dwells a yakṣa named Illuminator of Existence. Ānanda, in the western continent of Aparagodānīya there dwells a yakṣa named Great Activity. Ānanda, in the northern continent of Uttarakuru there dwells a yakṣa named Renowned. Ānanda, in the continent of Jambudvīpa there dwells a yakṣa named He Who Has Obtained Fame. Ānanda, those yakṣas too will come to hold one in mindful remembrance. Ānanda, those other yakṣas who feed on splendor and majesty will also come to obtain faith. And having obtained faith, they will proceed in order to obtain unshakeable faith.

Ānanda, in this regard, these are the words of vigilance taught by sages. Ānanda, you should hold fast to — and I have declared — the supreme words of the Tathāgata, the supreme among sages, which are words of non-harm toward all living beings and spirits.

Ānanda, even those yakṣas that follow in my wake will not be able to create obstacles.

Syād yathā dan, dandha ramahā hara hara mavara ṇa, rudra tra, kumati dritra, indra mantuke, avate, sahārā, sādhumati, ila lava mati, avati, tara para, yiviṣṭa, sada viṣṭa, ava tiṣṭha, pari vṛta, iśa vṛda, sada vṛta, krama krama ti ran, asiva cama la vi naha thi, ṭha śa sure, dhura dhura, ugra mugra, ugra pati, vi sara gra mati.

All the yakṣas, spirits, wandering beings (kumbhāṇḍas), hungry ghosts, flesh-eaters, nāgas, scent-eaters, and flesh-dwelling beings of the world-realm of the four great continents and all that dwells therein — those who reside within homes and those who travel the roads — having heard these words spoken by the Tathāgata, will become glad.

Ānanda, you should hold fast to these words of dhāraṇī mantra. You may feel regret later."

Then at that time the Blessed One spoke these verses:

These accomplished yakṣas
are chiefs in each of the four continents.
Whoever holds these secret mantras —
their mindfulness shall increase.

Those yakṣas who have come,
spoken of by the buddhas,
shall reveal to such a one
teachings of the dharma-kings that have declined.

Even traveling for many hundreds of leagues
gradually traversing the distance,
these words, profound and full of meaning,
should be heard and attended to.

These are the root of all Dharma.
Let the wise listen to them.

Even the fierce, upon hearing it, shall afterward be filled with supreme joy.
One in whom there is pleasure and no suffering — for such a one, joy shall arise.

This ground is without attachment; the ground of the buddhas is inconceivable. Having attained that immeasurable ground taught as being without attachment, one shines forth upon the surface of the earth just as the sun emerges from the clouds.

In this there are sense bases and aggregates, solitude and the limbs of awakening as sovereign, the profound teachings on virtuous Dharma — whatever the buddhas have spoken. The entire assembly of hearings thereof shall never be squandered. Having heard those teachings previously unheard, one becomes skilled in what is faulty and what is faultless. The supreme one who has absorbed understanding thoroughly — even those of failing sight shall

become pure.

One who upholds and teaches these is always praised by the buddhas.

With whatever truth one has that holds no doubt in the Dharmas of the buddhas, by that truth let all that exists come to rest in me as scriptural transmission.

With that truth — the truth of the buddhas abiding toward all beings with loving-kindness — let the Teacher come to abide in one's own mind and the minds of others.

The yakṣas dwelling in the four continents, displaying both the faithful and the faithless — to one in whom conceptual appearances do not arise, they shall reveal the full meaning of all of it.

The yakṣa Stargaze (Karadvīpa), the Elephant's Nose of distinctive power, the Fierce Joy-Maker, the Slayer, the Headless Moon, the Sheep-Slayer, the Brave Troop, Arm-Courage, the Rākṣasa, the Earth-Holder, Green-Mouth, Good-Ear, the Sword-Tufted Donkeys — may all of these be accomplished.

Whoever holds these secret mantras — those yakṣas and rākṣasas, roused to enthusiasm, shall draw them in, and constantly that one shall gain confidence, skill in words and in prophetic utterance, in definitive words and all Dharmas, and in letters. The scriptural transmission received shall not be squandered; understanding shall grow boundlessly. Always, in both meaning and in letters, that one's knowledge shall increase.

The gods of the Heaven of the Thirty-Three (Trāyastriṃśa), Brahmā the lord of the Sahā world — all those who hear that one's excellent discourse shall in that very moment recall it.

Syādyathedaṃ hukuna mukuna haraṇa vihāraṇa ísa saṃkramaṇa oṃ
sumukha takaṇa agaṇa apriya uṣṭhāme kobahare urupa pravāṇatan
saṃprameba hajagare praśigare guḍhavane uttana viguṇa íśakuna atula tula
aṃṭībaṭī varicamoṣa harajagata eva saṃpramukhe agavare ṭahuṣahu itiya
thāhu caturdvīpikayan ṭahuma hu uggrahu dhārasahu saṃgraha abina graha
abina graha prajñāvṛddhaye ṭahuṣahu karakuru dhasahu.

And here it should be said: whoever has these words of secret mantra upon their hand or body — that one shall hear and be without confusion; that one shall not be without wisdom. Just as a meteor, just as the sun, just as the moon shines forth — so too by hearing, and by its meaning, one shall reach as far as nirvāṇa.

Then at that time the Blessed One proclaimed these secret mantras:

Syādyathedaṃ cara dhevi cara dhe amaṃkute atimiti parahere ghaṇabhe
hibharme mahāpratibāhāne jaya jaya anuke palapale uggravati svara svara
abisare gugunde pravibṛdhe same ajite jaye nupalesu khomsusandhini
kumano sakṣe cāpicāpe cupe culuculu pulupulu byava prasare karakabhinde
bijāviṇe apratisandhi nānānumati pran anumati aridasi jeṣṭhanupanide asaṃgra
abati.

Whoever bears these words of the condensed mantra of vidyā upon their body
and carries them shall bring under their sway all the yakṣas, rākṣasas,
kumbhāṇḍas, hungry ghosts (pretas), and flesh-eaters dwelling in the
world-realm of the four great continents — and even those not yet brought
under sway shall be brought under sway. Likewise, in all one's affairs, just as
the Tathāgata has granted, one shall not die until the very end of one's life,
nor shall one be without means.

The rite for this is as follows. Dwelling in a secluded place, recite all these
dhāraṇī mantras continuously for seven days, recalling them three times by
day and three times by night. Then, after those seven days have passed, all
one's wishes shall be fulfilled.

Having spoken thus, the Blessed One fell silent, and the venerable Ānanda,
together with the entire assembly, and the gods, humans, asuras, and
gandharvas — the whole world — rejoiced and praised what the Blessed One
had proclaimed.

The noble dhāraṇī called The Ocean of Dharma is complete.

This was translated by the Indian preceptors Surendrabodhi and
Prajñāvarman, together with the great editor-translator the monk Ye shes sde
and others.

Translator's Notes

• The phrase rendered as "the comprehensive basis — the summation of all Dharmas"
translates 一切法之總持, which is somewhat technical and could
also be rendered "the basis of the summation of all Dharmas" or "the comprehensive gathering
that is the foundation of all Dharmas." The reading adopted reflects the likely sense of a
comprehensive doctrinal matrix being transmitted to Ānanda.

The term 鬼神 is uncertain; it may refer to a class of spirits or beings (possibly
kumbhāṇḍas, a class of goblins or spirits known in Buddhist cosmology). It has been rendered
as "spirits" in keeping with the contextual list of supernatural beings.

- The passage contains extended sequences of dhāraṇī syllables transliterated into Tibetan. These have been rendered as close phonetic approximations of the underlying Sanskrit rather than being left in Tibetan orthography. The reconstructed Sanskrit forms are approximate, as dhāraṇī syllable strings are often corrupt or intentionally opaque in transmission, and no single authoritative Sanskrit redaction has been used here as a control text.

The term ཀུམབ་མྱེད་པ་ rendered as "wandering beings (kumbhāṇḍas)" reflects the standard identification of this Tibetan word with the Sanskrit kumbhāṇḍa, a class of supernatural being sometimes described as pot-bellied spirits.

- The names of the yakṣas in the catalogue are extremely difficult to identify with precision. The Tibetan renderings appear to be phonetic transcriptions of Sanskrit or Prakrit originals that have become partly garbled in transmission. I have rendered them as descriptive epithets where the Tibetan yields legible meaning and left Karadvīpa as a reconstructed name for the star-faced yakṣa. Readers should treat the individual names as provisional.

The dhāraṇī syllables are transliterated as faithfully as the Tibetan phonetic spelling allows; they do not admit of standard Sanskrit normalization and are given here in approximate transcription only.

- The Tibetan colophon names three figures: the paṇḍitas Surendrabodhi and Prajñāvarman, and the Tibetan lo tsā ba Ye shes sde — a well-attested translation team active during the imperial period, which helps confirm the text's canonical standing. The term rendered "flesh-eaters" covers a class of malevolent beings (Tib. sha za) associated with the broader category of piśācas in Sanskrit; the Tibetan does not use the Sanskrit term explicitly, so it is glossed descriptively.

Colophon

This is an AI-generated translation from the AI Stupa project. It was produced by a careful, doctrine-aware process aiming at a high degree of accuracy, but it has not been reviewed by a human translator and may contain errors. It is offered as a provisional translation for those texts of the Tibetan Buddhist canon that have not yet received an authoritative human translation. Where a published translation exists — above all from 84000: Translating the Words of the Buddha (84000.co) — that translation is definitive and should be preferred; please consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.